the fall of these royal dynasties, they spread out to various trades and businesses and now form a successful and influential section of society. Over the centuries, these communities merged with the local Brahmins. Today, they are called Saurashtri Brahmins, and have taken local names and customs, but retain their culture, traditions and, distinctly, the Saurashtri language.

Saurashtri falls under the umbrella of Gujarati, but is nothing like the modern language. Over the past thousand years, Gujarati has taken words from Urdu, Arabic, Parsi, Turkish, Portuguese and English. The emigre Saurashtri, on the other hand, with a more archaic form of Prakrit as its base, has naturally absorbed influences from Marathi, Kannada, Telugu and Tamil. It is now an independent language with a script of its own.

Gujarat government spokesperson Rushikesh Patel says the population of Saurashtris in Tamil Nadu and other states is over 2.5 million. "They belong to the holy land of Somnath. As chief minister, Narendra Modi had invited the Saurashtri community to Saurashtra University in Rajkot in 2006 and rekindled the connection," he explains.

The *sangamam* event is part of the 'Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat' campaign of the central government which celebrates the unity in diversity motto. While the event is to highlight the "age-old connections of the two coastal states", there are of course political benefits to be reaped. Despite a majority of Tamil Nadu's population being Hindu, the BJP is finding it difficult to penetrate the state politically. Igniting a sense of belonging to Gujarat, a hint of *asmita* (pride) and appealing to the Saurashtra aspect of their identity could be useful in making inroads into the Dravidian heartland. Though not significant in numbers, the Saurashtri community is considered influential in business and trade. Roadshows were held in Chennai, Madurai, Dindigul, Paramakkudi, Salem, Kumbakonam, Thanjavur and Trichy to invite them to Saurashtra. These cities are reportedly home to 1.2 million Saurashtrians.



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THE SANGAMAM IS OFFICIALLY TO CONNECT SAURASHTRA TAMILS WITH THEIR HOMELAND BUT IT COULD REAP POLITICAL BENEFITS TOO

"A visit to the Somnath temple and the ancestral land, along with other tourism destinations in the state, will hopefully set off a word-of-mouth goodwill campaign about the Gujarat model of development, which is synonymous with the BJP," says a party spokesperson in Gujarat. Party workers in the respective districts were mobilised in huge numbers to interact with the visitors. The ensuing scenes were both heartwarming and amusing, as the visitors got emotional about reconnecting with their ancestors and the stories they have heard. At the same time, many of them were unable to communicate with the locals as the latter couldn't understand Saurashtri, and the visitors from Tamil Nadu didn't know much Hindi either. This left both sides fumbling with English as the only common language.

In 1947, after Independence, Kathiawar, as Saurashtra is also called, became an separate state. It is documented that a delegation of Saurashtra Tamils visited Saurashtra in 1949, but who exactly they visited is not known. However, since then the connection had been lying dormant, till Modi revived it in 2006. The *sangamam* saw a constant stream of visitors at other temple towns like Dwarka and Girnar too, along with tourist hotspots like the Gir wildlife sanctuary and Statue of Unity etc., the blazing heat of Gujarat notwithstanding. In fact, the people were brought to Gujarat on a special train. As per a schedule, local government officials treated the visitors as state guests. One of the visitors, K.V. Mahalaxmi from Madurai, summed it up, "We did not even dream that we would be able to come here ever. It means a lot that today we are on our ancestral land." ■